

Big Tech companies say AI will help solve climate change. Environmental groups call that ‘greenwashing’

Posted by u/_fastcompany • 0 points • 9 comments

As Big Tech faces criticism for the environmental impact of artificial intelligence, companies have said the technology will actually help solve climate change.

But those claims often lack scientific evidence, a new report finds. And when touting the climate benefits of AI, tech companies conflate “traditional AI” with the more environmentally harmful generative AI, a form of “bait-and-switch” that amounts to greenwashing.

The report, commissioned by a group of environmental organizations including Beyond Fossil Fuels, Friends of the Earth, and Stand.earth, analyzed 154 statements from tech companies, including those from Google and Microsoft, which purported that AI will have a “net climate benefit.”

Most of those comments relate to “traditional” AI, the analysis found, which has a smaller environmental footprint than the generative AI tools that are spurring a boom in data centers.

Tech companies, however, tend to lump these technologies together, the report says, blurring the differences and presenting the climate benefits and environmental harms as a “package deal.”

But whether those climate benefits are real is also unclear. Only 26% of those statements cite published academic papers, the research found, and 36% don’t cite any evidence at all.

Of the remaining statements, 29% cited corporate publications—the majority of which did not include peer-reviewed or published academic work—and 8% cited media, NGOs, or unpublished academic papers.

Comments

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-02-18 16:43 UTC

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u/MonoNoAware71 • 3 points • 2026-02-18 16:32 UTC

AI will help bring down emissions from commuters' cars because AI will make 10% of current jobs obsolete within the next ten years or so (according to AI 😊). So I guess they're not completely wrong.

Also, I think warfare might become more efficient, so also less emissions on that front.

We've known for years what we had to do to stop/slow down climate change. We just haven't done it and aren't doing it. AI is not going to change that.

u/Economy-Fee5830 • 0 points • 2026-02-18 16:31 UTC

The short-term claims are overblown, but long term there is every chance we can reverse climate change via mass automation e.g. building a million DAC modules in the same way we build 100 million cars each year.

u/Regular_Use1868 • 1 points • 2026-02-18 16:41 UTC

How would that help to address climate change? Legitimately curious.

u/Economy-Fee5830 • 0 points • 2026-02-18 16:45 UTC

Direct Air Carbon Capture sucks CO₂ from the atmosphere, which at scale reverses global heating.

u/Regular_Use1868 • 1 points • 2026-02-18 17:01 UTC

That's just more aimless hope man.

Carbon capture is a lie that we are being sold by polluting corporations.

In your proposed situation we would be hoping that AI invents a way to mass produce technology that we still have as of yet to make more effective at cleaning pollution than it produces pollution over its lifetime.

Probably a little too pie in the sky to be practical.

u/Economy-Fee5830 • 0 points • 2026-02-18 18:00 UTC

> In your proposed situation we would be hoping that AI invents a way to mass produce technology that we still have as of yet to make more effective at cleaning pollution than it produces pollution over its lifetime.

This is just uninformed - we have already decoupled development from emissions - its not very complicated to absorb more co₂ than we produce.

u/Regular_Use1868 • 1 points • 2026-02-18 18:05 UTC

How have we decoupled development from emissions?
Does making stuff not pollute things anymore?

Seriously if you can explain what that meant I'll be glad to entertain your ideas but right now this sounds like meaningless jargon to me.

It's also extremely complicated to remove CO2 from the atmosphere and takes electricity. I'm fairly certain the single net positive carbon capture system is in northern Europe and uses geothermal power. If you can point to another I'll happily Google it up myself.

u/Economy-
Fee5830
• 2 points
• 2026-
02-18
18:07
UTC

It's
simple -
China
made
billions
of solar
panels,
billions
of
batteries
and
millions
of EVs
and
their
emissions
went
down
last
year.

The
more
solar
panels
they
make
and
install
the

lower
their
emissions
will be.

It's
called
absolute
decoupling.

Look it
up.